

Douglas Budget

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Mike Moore photos

Sawyer Merchen can hardly wait another second to greet Santa as he and his younger brother Armin Merchen receive a special visit from the North Pole big man for boxes of gifts in Douglas Dec. 13.

A rattle at the door

Rotary Santa surprises 11 families with early Christmas

The frigid nighttime December air caused the glass door of the Merchen household to develop a cloudy layer of fog the night of Dec. 13, a full 12 days before the biggest holiday of them all.

Upon hearing a slight shuffle out in the street, a curious 3-year-old, Sawyer Merchen, slowly opened the front door and smeared his small hands across the glass in order to get a clear view of the commotion outside. What he was greeted by was a once-in-a-lifetime experience. Santa, himself, was slowly strolling up to the foot of his doorstep. Dressed in his vivid red and white coat, oversized belt buckle that twinkled under the night lights and jet-black leater boots, Santa captured Sawyer's eye immediately. The toddler's face and hands were glued to the glass.

Please see **SANTA VISIT,** page A-3

Walking by faith

By Colin Tiernan
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He woke when the sun rose, walked as far as he could, and pitched his tent at night.

"I believe I was in Arizona, and there wasn't nothing out there," Louis Grimes said. "It was 84 miles or about from the place I left to the next city, and there wasn't nothing, no rest area, no nothing."

Grimes walked along the highway, sleeping out in his tent for two or three nights, trekking during the day under a vicious Arizona sun.

"80 miles I knew I wasn't going to make (in one day)," he said. "It was also desert, and the temperature would get around 100 during midday, and then the temperature would drop to around freezing at night."



LOUIS GRIMES

Grimes walked the highways alone for 24 years, from California to the Carolinas, Washington to Florida. From town to town he evangelized, covering up to 50 miles a day, up to 5,000 miles a year, on his own.

He lived out of his backpack, ministering to all he met.

"With God's help I shared Jesus around the country," Grimes said.

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SOLD OUT

In its final hours after 56 years downtown, Home Bakery beseiged by one last rush

By Mary Stewart
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The chill in the early winter morning didn't stop anyone from coming. The news had ripped through town like a kid opening a Christmas present, and one by one people from all around were filing in through the door, hoping to get one last doughnut. Even with the best efforts, the shelves were almost empty by 8 that morning.

If you have lived in Douglas for any amount of time, attended a wedding or birthday or enjoyed the doughnuts that someone had brought into work, then you have experienced one of the tastiest treats around.

The two-story building across from the bowling alley has been a local establishment that generations of Douglasites have enjoyed. It was the place to go for some candy after a swim in the town pool on a hot summer day. The screen door creaks as you open it and the chime rings loud as you cross the threshold and step on the welcome mat.

Now after 56 years in business, the Home Bakery has closed its doors for good.

"We opened the place in 1962, I think," owner and baker George Smith recalled. "We opened it when we moved here to Douglas."

After considering a bakery job in Texas, George and his wife Mae came west from Nebraska to check out the new truck stop that was being built east of Douglas.

"We got lost in Glendo," Smith recalled with a laugh.

One of the original owners of the Big Wheel Truckstop moved the bakery to the building on Third Street, and the Smiths were offered the opportunity to run the bakery.

The building has a second floor which had eight small rooms for living quarters, which wouldn't work

Please see **HOME BAKERY,** page A-2



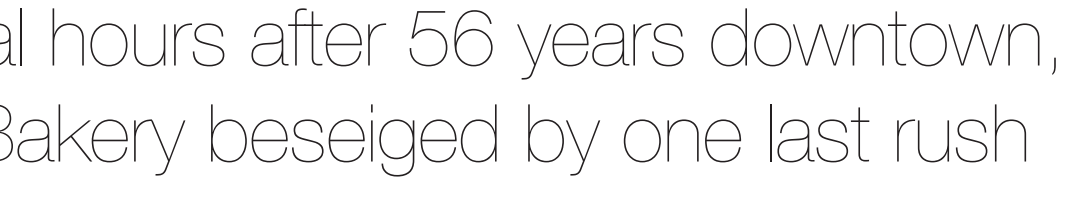
Mike Moore photos

Baker George Smith dips the fresh doughnuts into frosting early in the morning of Dec. 14. This would be the final batch of doughnuts that Smith would make and sell on the bakery's last day of business.

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This week's weather

	Wed.	Thur.	Fri.	Sat.	Sun.
High	45	48	53	40	43
Low	22	32	24	20	26



NEIGHBORS

Walking by faith



Louis

from the front page

Outfitted with a tent, sleeping bag, map, water and food, Grimes covered great distances by foot. People would often check on him while he was walking the highways, or offer him rides. When he reached towns, he would attend services.

"Usually I went to church on Sundays, and had a chance to share the Lord at church," he said. "People would ask questions when they saw my backpack and all."

FINDING A HOME IN DOUGLAS

If you've been in Douglas during the past 15 months, you've almost certainly seen Louis C. Grimes walking the streets, hardly missing a day.

Grimes is 65 years old, with a patchy salt-and-pepper beard. He speaks slowly and softly. Today he's wearing a banana-yellow jacket, brown Carhartts and black shoes. He carries a lightweight, collapsible rod to feel his way around: Six years ago, Grimes began gradually losing his sight. Today he can only see the vague outlines of shapes, provided they're extremely well-lit.

Grimes describes his vision loss as the result of "a strange and unusual occurrence" and adds that he has changed his life very little since his eyes started failing him.

He is matter-of-fact about going blind, only discussing the practical implications. For instance, he says figuring out what food's in which can at the grocery store is a chore, because he can only do it by ear, or ask for help.

The main change is that he can't preach like he used to, but despite that, losing his sight didn't plunge Grimes into despair. He says his faith prevented that.

"Being thankful to Jesus for his blessings, I believe that stopped me from having any dramatic emotional problems," he says. "I have faith that the Lord will return my vision to me."

Going blind hasn't stopped Grimes from his prodigious walking.

Senior Pastor at The Gathering Frank Wiederrecht says he's seen Grimes walking at 10:30 p.m. at night, and again at 6:30 a.m. the following morning.

"He often turns down rides so he can walk, I don't understand it," Wiederrecht says.

Grimes' ministering has brought him to 49 states. Visiting all 50 was a goal of his when he first began his ministry.

Grimes spent two weeks in Hawaii, four years in Alaska; remembers being impressed by the Old Man of the Mountain in New Hampshire, and thanks Jesus for the mild winters he experienced in New England. The one state he never passed through?

"I wasn't allowed to go to Nevada," he says, adding that he got as close as Lake Tahoe, which borders the state. "The Holy Spirit never allowed me to go to Nevada."

When reminiscing about his travels, Grimes primarily remembers the weather. Talking about his hometown of Baton Rouge, he mentions the lack of snow before anything else.

On a snowy Douglas day, Grimes says, "I thank the Lord I wore two coats."

Grimes slips into preacher mode often. Talking about his past on the highways reminds him of two chapters of the Bible. The loss of his vision brings to mind a parable. The Bible and Jesus are always on his mind, and he frequently describes his life into a Biblical context. For Grimes, he is in Douglas because God sees fit to have him here.

"He knows the Scriptures, oh by golly," Wiederrecht says, noting that Grimes practically has the Bible memorized, even though he can't read it anymore (he listens to it on CDs). "If he can't quote them verbatim he knows the gist of it and where it's at . . . That's pretty impressive."

After ministering on the road since his 20s, Grimes has finally settled down in Wyoming. Six years ago he applied for housing in Cheyenne and lived there for several years. Then he stopped briefly in Casper, and for the past 15 months he has lived in an apartment in Douglas. These days there's a well-decorated Christmas tree inside his modest place, leaning against his window.

A MINISTRY BORN IN BATON ROUGE

Grimes grew up with five brothers and two sisters, to parents who ran a grocery store and worked construction respectively. The Civil Rights movement was coursing through the South during his childhood, but he doesn't remember it as having changed his life all that much.

In the '70s, Grimes left home to begin his ministry. He didn't set out on foot.

"I did it by automobile, (a 1967 Ford Falcon he thinks) and bus," he said.

He worked odd jobs, like welding and construction, over the years, and said he didn't really feel disadvantaged by the color his skin, maintaining that so long as he provided good work, no one seemed to care.

The police didn't harass him while he was walking either, although they frequently came

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LOUIS,
page B-7



> "I wasn't allowed to go to Nevada. The Holy Spirit never allowed me to go to Nevada.'
>
> **Louis Grimes on his travels to 49 states. He walked to most of them.**



Colin Tiernana photos

Louis Grimes has a special machine that can scan a page and read the text aloud to him.
April Petty (photo at left) helps Louis through an icy stretch outside The Gathering.



A veteran walker, Grimes makes his way home in a snowstorm along Fourth Street earlier this month.

Louis

from page B-6



Senior Pastor at The Gathering Frank Wiederrecht shakes hands with Louis Grimes while Rooster Baumann looks on.

up to him. They often offered him rides, and rarely gave him a hard time.

Despite ministering for decades, solo, Grimes says that Jesus prevented him from feeling lonely.

"He (Jesus) fulfills everything for me," Grimes said.

Walking attracted people to him and Jesus made him a light, Grimes said. Those qualities helped him spread the Gospel. People would take an interest in him when they drove past, and sometimes they'd come back later in the day.

"People just wanted to see how far I got," Grimes said.

SERENE SUNDAYS

At The Gathering, Grimes' face takes on the same serene appearance it has when he listens to the Bible in his apartment.

He looks relaxed this Sunday morning. Cheerful. He claps enthusiastically along with the music. He listens intently to Pastor Wiederrecht's sermon.

After the service, members of the congregation come up to Grimes, unbidden. They are eager to talk with him.

"You're such an inspiration," Pat "Rooster" Baumann tells him. "You minister to people you don't even know about. You're amazing."

Grimes' face, typically impassive, lights up with a huge smile at these words. He looks especially calm here, peaceful. This is the way he looks when listening to the Bible in his apartment.

"He's just an awesome guy," Wiederrecht said. "It's obvious God lives within him."

Wyoming has poor church attendance, Grimes says, and he wonders if God has placed him in Wyoming for that very reason.

"God puts me where he likes," Grimes said.

Grimes settled down in Wyoming because he was ready to rest. And he is resting after his decades on the road, even though he walks up to three times per day.

"I'm walking by faith."



Grimes leafs through two of his well-worn Bibles in his apartment.

INSURANCE *Identity Thieves*

Tips to Keep Identity Thieves Out of Your Home and Small Business

We have become dependent on the convenience of having our financial accounts, healthcare information and personal profiles just a click or two away. Whether you use a desktop, laptop, tablet or a smartphone to access the Internet, this convenience comes with a responsibility to be vigilant with regards to basic cybersecurity. The Wyoming Department of Insurance offers the following tips to help keep your identity safe and your business secure.

Security Starts at Home

Your Wi-Fi router is the first line of defense for your home's Internet network. To make sure no one is accessing your Wi-Fi, you should occasionally change the router's administrator login, enable encryption and change default passwords. If you want to share your Wi-Fi with guests, you can do that safely by providing them with guest network access.

Viruses and malware are a constant threat. Investing in antivirus and anti-malware software is a necessary expense to protect your identity and personal information.

Sensitive information, such as your social security number, confidential business, bank information, medical records and tax returns should never be sent over email or other communication channels without encryption.

Be Aware of Your Surroundings

Whether you are sitting in a coffee shop, a shared workspace, or on public transportation for your daily commute, keep in mind there are individuals who may be listening to your conversations or are able to see your screens. Do not read your credit card number or discuss your bank account or other personal information in a public setting.



Cyber thieves have created information-skimming devices that are attached to ATMs, gas pumps and other Point of Sale (POS) devices. Once you enter your PIN, thieves have access to everything they need to clean out your bank account. Watch out for any card-swiping devices that look suspicious.

Password Protection

Along with the convenience of our online lifestyle comes the need for an endless number of passwords. Security experts suggest you memorize the most important ones and write the rest down, keeping them in a safe place. Keep this data secure, and do not keep your account numbers and passwords in the same place. If you keep a list of passwords on your phone, laptop or even in the cloud, avoid naming that file "Passwords."

Experts recommend passwords with a combination of upper and lowercase letters, numbers and symbols. Two-factor authentication offers an extra layer of security by requiring a password, a username, as well as something only the user has access to when logging in. This might include a specific piece of information only they should know—or a physical token, a fingerprint or facial recognition. Two-factor authentication can be added to your social media accounts, mobile phones, email and bank accounts.

Think Before You Click

If you see an email from an address you do not recognize, proceed with caution and never click on attachments or links in emails that seem suspicious. With one click, you could infect your computer with viruses or malware that may not be detected for months. In the meantime, your data has been compromised and you may have invited an identity thief into your system.

Hackers use fake web addresses (URLs) that seem completely normal to break into systems. One way to stay safe online is to look for spelling or grammatical errors in domain names and email addresses.

Securing a Small Business

About half of all small businesses experience a cyberattack because they generally have a moderate amount of data and usually have minimal cybersecurity.

Small businesses should secure their Wi-Fi networks, train employees on cyber security, and consider using third-party security companies to protect their data. Cyber liability insurance can help a small business survive cyber attacks by paying for customer notification, credit monitoring, legal fees and fines after a data breach.

More Information

The National Association of Insurance Commissioners (NAIC) has published a Roadmap for Cybersecurity Consumer Protection at: https://www.naic.org/documents/committees_ex_cybersecurity_tf_related_roadmap_cybersecurity_consumer_protections.pdf.

Also, the Federal Deposit Insurance Corporation (FDIC) hosts a wealth of information on cybersecurity. The Federal Trade Commission (FTC) has an identity theft website to report incidents and develop a recovery plan after a cybersecurity attack.

Wyoming Department of Insurance
http://doi.wyo.gov / 1 (800) 438-5768

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